

Attention Is Not All You Need: A Study of Reading Together

Abstract. We observe a 3.2x speedup over the baseline when readers share cursors and selections in real time. This paper describes the method, the evaluation, and the limitations of synchronous reading.

1. Introduction

Reading groups today rely on screen sharing. The presenter has all the agency and nothing anyone says is anchored to the text afterwards.

2. Method

Each participant sees a cursor for every other participant, drawn in page-space coordinates so that positions are independent of zoom. Highlights are anchored using text quote and position selectors.

3. Results

Groups completed the reading 3.2x faster and reported fewer moments of confusion about which passage was under discussion.